

ISHAN TANKHA



AIR-HOSTESS ACADEMY
Ludhiana | PUNJAB



Flight plan

Aisles in the air are to small town girls in the noughties what fashion ramps were to women in the '90s. A one-way ticket to glamour.

■ By Ramesh Vinayak

In the chaotic hub of Bharat Nagar Chowk, Ludhiana, signboards of singers and sex specialists are omnipresent. Now, jostling for space on the facades of shopping arcades are colourful hoardings for air-hostess training academies. These are the new dream factories in an industrial city famous for its entrepreneurship. Founded over the past one year, they promise young girls careers in the aviation and hospitality sectors. One such institute is Flying Cats located in a nondescript complex that also houses an air travel agency, a furniture showroom, a private finance company and a sexologist.

"Through short-term courses, we polish them for a long-term career," says branch manager Deepa Nayyar in a clipped accent, referring to the one-year certificate course that Flying Cats offers as part of its 'perk-up-your-personality' package. Inside the cabin classrooms, a clutch of girls in air-hostess uniforms are groomed so they can achieve the perfect poise and the ultimate accent. Roughly 60 per cent of them come from the rural hinterland, which has become a catchment area for these academies. Most of them are college-going girls, who opt for crash courses to pursue an al-

ternative career.

Take 18-year-old Navjot Kaur Grewal, from Shehjadpur village, 20 km from the city. "Grooming is like a fixed deposit which one can encash for a bunch of jobs," she says. Her mother is the village sarpanch who encouraged her to take the course. "My parents want me to live my dream," she says, in a newly cultivated neutral accent honed through hours of speaking in front of the mirror. Like Grewal, 17-year-old Harpreet Kaur comes from Kotla Dadheri village, 50 km from Ludhiana. "Coming from a middle class family, I know the value of my parents' money and want to make them proud," she says. She is pursuing the air-hostess training alongside her graduation at a local college. She shuttles between her village and the city in a salwar kameez but changes into a skirt the minute she reaches the academy.

The real surprise, says Meetu Nayyar, a grooming expert for the Flying Cats, is the ambition of these small town girls. She compares girls like Grewal and Kaur to clay, easy to mould. "The city-bred girls often have an attitude which we have to tone down," she says. For women like 21-year-old Manu Bhardwaj, from Giaspura village, a career in aviation holds more weight than a post-graduate degree in mathematics, which she left mid-way to join Flying Cats. "This is a woman-led industry and the sky is no limit in this career," she says, in fluent English and an airbrushed attitude.

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PER CENT OF
WANNABE AIR-
HOSTESSES IN THE
FLYING CATS ACADEMY
ARE FROM VILLAGES